

Erik Drouhard

AI DESIGN ENGINEER

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SUMMARY

AI design engineer who turns complex AI and technical systems into understandable, testable product experiences.

Combines interaction design, front-end engineering, rapid prototyping, and design systems to help teams make decisions earlier and create more predictable human-agent interactions.

Core Skills: AI Design Engineering, Human-Agent Interaction, Agentic UX, Rapid Prototyping, Design Systems, Interaction Design, Conversational and Multimodal Interfaces, Complex Systems UX, Behavior Authoring, Cross-Functional Leadership, Accessibility, Usability Testing, Context Engineering

Tools & Technologies: Figma, Framer, HTML, CSS, SCSS, JavaScript, TypeScript, React, Next.js, Git, GitHub

AI & Agent Tooling: Claude Code, OpenAI Codex, GitHub Copilot CLI, OpenCode, agentic coding workflows, spec-driven development, LLM-assisted prototyping and evaluation

EXPERIENCE

Microsoft

June 2017 - Present

Joined Nuance Communications in June 2017; became a Microsoft employee through the March 2022 acquisition and moved into the Copilot Studio org in August 2023.

UX Engineer II, CoreAI

March 2025 - Present

- Co-lead prototyping and tooling across Microsoft AI Foundry and Azure portals, building focused mini-apps, reusable agent skills, and internal workflows for a 10-person team within a 30+ person design organization.
- Reduced prototype turnaround from weeks to hours, letting teams explore, test, and validate directions before committing engineering resources.
- Equip the immediate team and broader design organization with AI skills, spec-driven development, workflow optimization, weekly learning sessions, and hands-on guidance.

Product Designer II, Copilot Studio

August 2023 - March 2025

- Designed and prototyped builder-facing experiences for conversational AI tools, partnering with design and engineering on complex AI-driven workflows.
- Planned and facilitated a 3-day stakeholder sprint that translated deep behavior-authoring expertise into prioritized support for nested conditions and aligned the group on the highest-value capabilities.
- Promoted from Product Designer I to Product Designer II.

Senior UX Engineer, Verse Design System · Nuance Communications

November 2022 - August 2023

- Led design and front-end architecture for Verse, an accessible React design system built on Radix and vanilla-extract as the shared UI foundation for Mix, Nuance's primary voice IVR and virtual assistant platform; established shared components, patterns, tokens, and implementation practices.
- Coordinated architecture, governance, and adoption planning across multiple engineering and design teams serving Nuance's CoreAI R&D organization; a Verse talk drew 60+ attendees and ranked among the internal conference sessions with the largest attendance.

Senior UX Designer, Mix.dialog · Nuance Communications

February 2019 - November 2022

- Led interaction design for conditions, QA, questions, and channel and modality authoring in Mix.dialog, Nuance's primary tool for building voice IVR and virtual assistant experiences, including work with Sony Interactive Entertainment on PlayStation 5 and close partnership with Rakuten.
- In a longitudinal study with 17 IVR and digital virtual assistant designers, the new condition stack raised CSAT from 5.0 to 7.0 (+40%) and SUS from 52.67 to 61.50 (+8.83 points); both gains were statistically significant at $p < .05$.
- Made the multi-year case for a platform design system and secured leadership buy-in, then defined token and component architecture with front-end engineering from 2021, work that became Verse.

UI/UX Designer, Dragon Drive, Mix, Swype · Nuance Communications

June 2017 - February 2019

- Led UI and interaction design for the centerpiece of Nuance's CES 2019 automotive presence: a stationary 220-degree immersive demo combining a windshield HUD, gaze, voice, and real-time multimodal feedback.
- The showcase supported work with Daimler (Mercedes-Benz); the wider Dragon Drive platform powered 250M+ cars across 40+ languages before Nuance's automotive business was spun out as Cerence in 2019.

Applause

April 2016 - March 2017

Front-End Developer & Designer

- Led front-end development for Applause.com, a custom WordPress installation with multi-language support, working directly with marketing leadership and partnering with design and international engineering teams.
- Directed a shift to a headless architecture (Contentful, Middleman, Vue) to reduce the legacy CMS's vulnerability exposure and publishing-approval latency; selected and built the stack through to pre-launch before departing.

Cold Spring Design

April 2011 - February 2016

Web Designer

- Led visual design and front-end development for marketing websites using HTML, SCSS, jQuery, and WordPress.

EDUCATION

American International College

Master Certificate, Visual Communications